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Episode 220: Marathon Men (Part 1)

April 15, 2022

with Brace & Liz
guests Ben Howard, Howie

Sample excerpt, 15:00-25:00

Transcribed with Whisper and pyannote, then proofread. Speaker labels are automatic and may contain mistakes.

BRACE 15:00
Oh, thank you for joining us, and thank you for suffering through that intro.

BEN 15:03
Thank you for having me again. It's always a pleasure to be here.

HOWIE 15:07
Yeah, thanks for having me. I'm excited to be here.

BRACE 15:10
Howie, welcome.

HOWIE 15:12
Yeah, thanks.

BRACE 15:14
We got to get your guys' parents and uncles on this thing. The whole family. Yeah. So, fellas, we— of course, we needed our two Boston correspondents here with us to go through— I mean, we are at the ninth anniversary of the bombings this year.

HOWIE 15:32
Yeah.

LIZ 15:33
Yep.

BRACE 15:33
This week, just in a couple days. Yeah, exactly. It should be when this— if we time this right, I can't remember what we talked about, but when this episode comes out. If I'm wrong on that, please don't get mad at me or leave a comment or anything like that. But we've wanted to do this episode with you guys for a while. And yeah, I'm glad to finally be here.

This is a big subject.

BEN 15:56
The amount of stuff— I'm just looking at our notes. It's like, you know, 30 pages, just because there's so much—

LIZ 16:02
For part one only.

BEN 16:03
Yeah, there's so much that happens, and there are so many details that matter, because there's so, so many inconsistencies with the various stories that have come out about this. So I'm excited for people to sit through presumably hours of us discussing this.

BRACE 16:19
Yeah. So, I mean, the sort of, like, back-of-the-novel story of the Boston bombing is: two brothers, both weed smokers and radical Islamists, were so fed up with America and hated the country so much that they decided to bomb the oldest marathon that's still ongoing in the world, causing mass casualties— you know, three deaths and a ton of pretty horrific injuries. They are engaged in a long manhunt with the police, and eventually one is killed and the other is captured. And there has been sort of an ongoing series of court cases. And that is kind of the official narrative. There's probably something more to it, though, right?

LIZ 17:01
Yeah, hours more of explanation needed, because that's not exactly what happened here. I feel like before we get into the nitty-gritty details

and then jump into the timeline of the bombing, and then where we're kind of going with the rest of the series— I feel like whenever Ben's on, we kind of have to start in the same place, which is the World Trade Center. And I promise I'm not actually going to link the Boston bombing to September 11th, but I just thought that would be a cute thing to say.

But I kind of want to mention something to begin our conversation, which is that for people who are either too young, which is most of our listeners probably, or too baby-brained, which is like the other half of our listeners probably— for those who don't remember, the World Trade Center was actually bombed prior to 9/11, back in 1993. And I think that bombing— I can't totally— I think it was like six people died, but it wounded over a hundred. It was like billions of dollars of damages. It was a huge, huge case.

And during that, the ensuing trial and the case that came out of it, this man named Emad Salem kind of came forward. And he was an Egyptian army officer who had been turned an informant for the FBI. And probably due to the fact that he was Egyptian army trained, he ended up actually taping all of his conversations. Which, by the way, TrueAnon hot tip: if you ever get turned to be a criminal informant for the FBI— which, by the way, first off, don't do that. But second off, if you do, tape all of your conversations, because this guy did. And somehow the New York Times got a hold of all of those tapes.

And so I'm just going to read really quickly some of the reporting from the New York Times there, because I just want to— I think this is a good way to just kind of— something to keep in mind as we start going through this story of the Boston bombing:

"Law enforcement officials were told that terrorists were building a bomb that eventually used to blow up the world— that was eventually used to blow up the World Trade Center, and that they planned to thwart the plotters by secretly substituting harmless powder for the explosives, the informer said after the blast. The informer was to have helped the plotters build the bomb and supply the fake powder, but the plan was called off by an FBI supervisor who had ideas about how the informer, Emad A. Salem, should be used. The transcripts are being closely studied by lawyers looking for signs that Mr. Salem and law enforcement officials, in their zeal to gather evidence, may have crossed the legal line into entrapment, a charge that the defense counsel has already raised. The tapes offer a rare glimpse into the sensitive relationship between the confidential informer and the law enforcement officials with whom he worked. They also reveal for the first time how federal and police agents instructed him to pump up a suspect for information, and negotiate a $1 million fee from the government for his services."

So we've done episodes— we did an episode on the Gretchen Whitmer plot. We haven't done an episode on Whitey Bulger, but people are probably pretty familiar with that case, which I

actually think was kind of going to trial right at the same time as the Boston bombing, weirdly enough.

BRACE 20:14
Big year for Boston.

LIZ 20:16
Yeah, big, big year. But Boston itself has had a very kind of, let's say, close-knit relationship with the FBI, the mob, and whatever kind of blurry line— I don't know— counts as some kind of border in between the two of those. They kind of blur into one another in Boston in a lot of instances. But I just wanted to kind of, you know, use that as a frame: the history of the FBI and criminal informants kind of being involved, and more often than not— I don't know, yeah, like this New York Times piece says— crossing the line over into entrapment. I mean, history is dotted with cases like this, probably more than people want to admit to themselves.

HOWIE 21:01
I was going to say that there's some interesting ties with the Boston FBI and Lady al-Qaeda as well. And I believe— I can't remember the other— gosh, I'm blanking on his name, but there was— yeah. So, I mean, on top of the Whitey Bulger thing, obviously, where Whitey was on the payroll as an informant and murdering his adversaries, basically.

BRACE 21:27
Yeah, that was a big scandal, is that, like, basically the Boston FBI was overseeing this guy murdering his political— or not his political,

rather, his criminal enemies, and kind of just, like, letting him have this reign of terror because he gave them some information he liked and probably, you know, he did some work for them.

Well, it's not just the Boston FBI that uses these methods, either. I mean, the FBI writ large has made extensive use of CIs, confidential informants, basically really since the 1950s, in a major way. I mean, they always have. That's always been sort of a feature of, especially, like, secret or political police. But the use of informants and snitches and essentially, like, criminals working for the United States government has increased exponentially every single year, basically since the early '60s. You know, in the aftermath of 9/11, it became a huge tactic, especially for law enforcement in the Northeast. I mean, NYPD is famous for this kind of stuff. But yeah, I mean, as we can see with the Whitmer stuff, this is really ongoing and continues to be a very valuable tool in the old FBI tool kit—tool chest, wherever they keep their tools. I guess probably buried in someone's, like, work shed, along with, like, a bunch of nuts and bolts and gunpowder and stuff like that.

LIZ 22:48

Okay, so the Tsarnaev brothers. Let's talk about them before we get into what happened on that fateful Wednesday, I believe, morning. Brace, do you want to give us a little high-level rundown of these two guys?

BRACE 23:08
All right, so Dzhokhar and Tamerlan, the two Tsarnaev brothers, two out of four siblings, are the sons of Anzor and Zubeidat. Am I pronouncing that right? Do you guys know how to pronounce this?

HOWIE 23:20
I have no idea how to pronounce his mother's name.

BRACE 23:23
We're going with Zubeidat. Anzor is the father. He is a Chechen, and Zubeidat is an Avar. They are from originally— I believe they met, actually, in Siberia, where Zubeidat had— I think she had moved to stay with her brother. Anzor was doing his mandatory military service. They had a kid— I believe the day after they were married, he was born. That's Tamerlan. And then they moved to Kyrgyzstan, where they had three more children: Bella, Ailina, and finally, little Dzhokhar.

They moved to Chechnya in 1993. And this is where the story gets a little funky, because Anzor's story changes kind of depending on who he's talking to. His official story is that— I mean, when they moved there in '93, the First Chechen War breaks out in 1994. The First Chechen War was hugely devastating, a major conflict between the Russian government and rebels in Chechnya. And Anzor says that he was kidnapped and taken to a camp for Muslims by the Russian government. That's, like, where his sort of— he says— PTSD comes from. I don't know if there's actually any proof of that. I know he said that to get asylum in the

U.S., but he said kind of a lot of things. He said he was tortured by the FSB. But they move out of Chechnya shortly after that, which is rather understandable, and I believe move back to Kyrgyzstan. So in 2002, the parents come to America on a 90-day visa with little Dzhokhar in tow— I think he's about three years old— and apply for asylum based on—